



*Rise. Register. Grow.*

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*In business, leaders often talk about a "VUCA" world — one defined by Volatility, Uncertainty, Complexity, and Ambiguity (Bennett & Lemoine, 2014). Prices shift overnight, regulations change, and the road to formalising a small food business can feel impossible to predict. That is exactly the world our traders are operating in. So in this VUCA world, we are here to help you VUKA ;-)*

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## **Journey 6: Let Your Phone Bring You Customers**

This is **Journey 06** of the VUKA curriculum: every journey a food trader needs, from checking whether you're ready to grow, right through to scaling into a bigger business, in one consistent, scenario-driven format.

*Each lesson takes 3–7 minutes: a real scenario, a quick explanation, one practical tip, a quick challenge, and a badge.*

### **What's Inside:**

|                                                                                   |          |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| → 📱 Journey 6: Let Your Phone Bring You Customers.....                            | 2        |
| → 📱 Set Up WhatsApp Business.....                                                 | 2        |
| 📋 Build a Catalogue Customers Can Browse.....                                     | 2        |
| 🔗 Connect Facebook and Instagram.....                                             | 2        |
| 📷 Take Photos People Want to Eat.....                                             | 3        |
| 💡 Never Run Out of Things to Post.....                                            | 3        |
| Sources for Fact-Checking: Legislation & Regulation.....                          | 3        |
| Sources & Further Reading: Business Practice, Marketing & Financial Literacy..... | 4        |
| <b>Sources &amp; Further Reading: The VUCA Concept.....</b>                       | <b>4</b> |



## → Journey 6: Let Your Phone Bring You Customers

*"Your food sells itself once people taste it. But how do they find you before that?"*

Almost everyone in South Africa already uses WhatsApp, and it's free to use for business, only data is needed, which is cheaper than airtime. Very few food sellers set it up the right way. Done properly, it makes your business look professional and lets regular customers order ahead or check what's on the menu today.

### → Set Up WhatsApp Business

*"Someone wants to order 10 plates for a stokvel meeting. Can they message you, or do they have to physically find your stall first?"*

Download "WhatsApp Business" (not regular WhatsApp) from the Play Store or App Store, it's free. Register with a phone number, either a second SIM if you want to keep business and personal chats separate, or your existing number if it isn't already linked to regular WhatsApp. Verify the number by SMS code, then set up your Business Profile: business name, category ("Food & Beverage"), a short description of what you sell, your trading location and hours, and a clear profile photo of your food, stall, or logo.

 **QUICK TIP** Set a greeting message (e.g. "Thanks for messaging Thandi's Kota Corner! We're open Mon–Fri, 6am–17:30 at the taxi rank.") so customers get an instant response, even while you're busy serving.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Download the app and complete your profile: name, category, description, hours, and photo.

Complete this and earn: →  "Business Ready" badge

### Build a Catalogue Customers Can Browse

*"A regular customer wants to know what's on the menu today, without calling you. What do they actually see?"*

Under the Tools/Business Tools menu, select "Catalogue" and add your items, a photo, name, and price for each. Share your WhatsApp number or link with customers by writing it on a small sign or your menu board at your stall, so people can save it.

 **QUICK TIP** Keep your catalogue updated when items sell out or prices change. An outdated catalogue creates awkward conversations, not sales.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Add your 3 best-selling items to your catalogue with a photo, name, and price.

Complete this and earn:  "Catalogue Built" badge

### Connect Facebook and Instagram

*"Someone finds your food on Instagram. Can they message you straight from there, or do they have to go searching for your number separately?"*

Facebook and Instagram can find your next customer, and you can connect them from the WhatsApp Business app itself. Open the app and go to Tools, tap Facebook & Instagram, then tap through to connect whichever platform you use. Log in to your Facebook or Instagram account, select the Page you want to link, and tap Connect WhatsApp.

 **QUICK TIP** You don't need both platforms at once. Start with whichever one your customers already use most.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Link one social media account to your WhatsApp Business this week.

Complete this and earn:  "Connected" badge



## Take Photos People Want to Eat

*"Would a photo of your food make a stranger hungry, or would they scroll straight past it?"*

A photo of your food often decides whether a customer wants to try your dish or not. The picture sets the mood and makes people feel hungry before they've even tasted anything. That's why it matters for customers to see pictures of your food, whether on your menu or your WhatsApp catalogue. Good food photos also get people talking, sharing, commenting, and tagging friends. Posts with images get far more views than posts with text alone (candyfoxstudio.com), so an appetising photo can create more interest than any description ever could.

 **QUICK TIP** Natural light does more for a food photo than any filter. Shoot near a window or outside, not under a dim stall light.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Take one appetising photo of your best-selling dish today, and save or post it.

Complete this and earn:  **"Camera Ready" badge**

## Never Run Out of Things to Post

*"It's been two weeks since your last post. What's actually stopping you?"*

To keep your social media active without running out of ideas, share everyday moments from your business: preparing food, answering common customer questions, showing off your most popular menu items, or celebrating milestones. Keep an "idea bank" on your phone, a running list of trends, funny videos, and memorable pictures, so you always have content ready to post (Mercer, 2026).

 **QUICK TIP** You don't need a big production. A quick, honest photo of your actual stall usually beats a polished but generic one.

 **QUICK CHALLENGE** Start an "idea bank" note on your phone with three post ideas you could use this month.

Complete this and earn:  **"Idea Bank" badge**

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## Sources for Fact-Checking: Legislation & Regulation

Every legal fact in Journeys 3, 4, and 10 is drawn from current South African legislation and regulator guidance:

- Regulations Governing General Hygiene Requirements for Food Premises (R638 of 2018), under the Foodstuffs, Cosmetics and Disinfectants Act 54 of 1972 — enforced by municipal Environmental Health Departments.
- Regulations Relating to the Labelling and Advertising of Foodstuffs (R146), under the Foodstuffs, Cosmetics and Disinfectants Act 54 of 1972 — Department of Health.
- Businesses Act 71 of 1991 — gov.za.
- Companies Act 71 of 2008 and Companies and Intellectual Property Commission (CIPC) — company registration, business structure conversion, and trade mark registration — cipc.co.za.
- National Regulator for Compulsory Specifications (NRCS), Food and Associated Industries division — canned, smoked, and vacuum-packed products — nrcs.org.za.
- South African Revenue Service (SARS), Small Businesses – Taxpayers, Tax Compliance Status system, and Budget 2026 Frequently Asked Questions (VAT and Turnover Tax threshold changes effective 1 April 2026) — sars.gov.za.
- Unemployment Insurance Act 63 of 2001 and Unemployment Insurance Contributions Act 4 of 2002 — Department of Employment and Labour — labour.gov.za.
- Compensation for Occupational Injuries and Diseases Act 130 of 1993 (COIDA) — Compensation Fund, Department of Employment and Labour — labour.gov.za.



- Basic Conditions of Employment Act 75 of 1997 — Department of Employment and Labour — [labour.gov.za](http://labour.gov.za).
- National Environmental Management: Waste Act 59 of 2008 and Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) Regulations (Government Notice R.1184, 2020) — Department of Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment — [dffe.gov.za](http://dffe.gov.za).
- Broad-Based Black Economic Empowerment Act 53 of 2003, and the Codes of Good Practice on B-BBEE (Exempted Micro-Enterprise thresholds) — [dtic.gov.za](http://dtic.gov.za).
- Protection of Personal Information Act 4 of 2013 (POPIA) — Information Regulator South Africa — [info regulator.org.za](http://info regulator.org.za).
- Consumer Protection Act 68 of 2008 — online and distance sales provisions — [gov.za](http://gov.za).
- African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) — South African implementation guidance — [dtic.gov.za](http://dtic.gov.za).

*Note: municipal fees, thresholds, and application processes vary by area and are periodically revised by government and regulators. Verify current requirements directly with the relevant municipality or regulator before publishing final figures in the app.*

## Sources & Further Reading: Business Practice, Marketing & Financial Literacy

*Branding and digital marketing facts in Journeys 6 and 7 draw on the following:*

- Cloudfusion (2025). 7 Essential Reasons Why Branding Is Important for Business. [cloudfusion.co.za](http://cloudfusion.co.za).
- Dandu, R. (2015). What Is Branding and Why Is It Important for Your Business? [brandingmag](http://brandingmag.com).
- Mercer, S. (2026). What to Post When You Have Nothing to Post: 10 Content Ideas for Summerville Businesses. What's Up Summerville.
- Why food photography is important for your food business. [candyfoxstudio.com](http://candyfoxstudio.com).
- Yolisa Motha (2021). A Guide to Branding a Small Business. [ikhokha](http://ikhokha.com).

*Statistics on South African small business communication, time management, professionalism, networking, record-keeping, and banking (Journeys 1, 2, 8, and 9) are drawn from national small business research. Verify current figures against original sources before publishing final numbers in the app.*

*Growth-readiness, lending-risk, funding, and stock-management facts in Journeys 1, 2, 5, and 9 draw on the following:*

- National Debt Advisors (2021). Stay away from unregistered money-lenders. [nationaldebtadvisors.co.za](http://nationaldebtadvisors.co.za).
- Startup Mag (2025). Scaling Signals: Ten Signs Your Small Business Is Ready to Grow. [startupmag.co.za](http://startupmag.co.za); Lula (2025). 5 Signs Your Business is Ready for Growth Capital. [lula.co.za](http://lula.co.za).
- RegInsights (2024). Small Business Funding. [regenesys.net/reginsights](http://regenesys.net/reginsights).
- Graduates24 (n.d.). NYDA Grant Programme Small Business Funding in South Africa. [graduates24.com](http://graduates24.com).
- Okhantu (2025). SEDFA Funding 2026: Requirements, Amounts & How to Apply. [okhantu.co.za](http://okhantu.co.za).
- Ready Accounting (2026). Inventory management tips for cost savings and efficiency. [readyaccounting.co.za](http://readyaccounting.co.za).
- Xtraspace (2024). Small Business Inventory Management in SA: 10 Top Tips. [xtraspace.co.za](http://xtraspace.co.za).

## Sources & Further Reading: The VUCA Concept

*The mission statement on the cover page draws on the following:*

- Bennett, N., & Lemoine, G. J. (2014). What VUCA Really Means for You. *Harvard Business Review*, 92(1/2), 27.

